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JERUSALEM INTERNATIONAL FELLOWS

Dear <<First Name>>,

I am experiencing cognitive dissonance. Ceasefire. Release of three hostages. Resignation of Ben Gvir. Inauguration of Trump. It all leaves me hopeful and terrified at the same time.

Below I've shared two pieces that talk about artists and their power to bring people together. And the need for multiple perspectives to be heard.

The first is r

https://www.rockefellerfoundation.org/bellagio-bulletin/the-people-and-ideas-of-bellagio/vibha-galhotra-and-elise-bernhardt/?utm_source=email&utm_medium=email&utm_campaign=bellagio

My favorite takeaway:

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important issue in the world. It's something we all need to work on, rather than worrying about our differences," she said.

Vibha and Elise agree that art can be a powerful tool to drive forward productive conversation about difficult topics. "Generally speaking, I think art is one of the only ways to engage people in constructive dialogue around these issues. Artists are able to get people to communicate," Elise said.

Vibha understands the role she plays as an artist engaged in social issues. "Art has a great power to tell stories and bring people into conversation through empathy. If we use it right, we can definitely lead to a better world," she said.

Vibha believes that immersive experiences like "Who Owns the Water?" can be transformative. "They can change the world slowly, not by pointing fingers towards anyone but by raising the issues and creating space for discussion and collaboration."



The opening of Vibha's installation Mountain to the Sea at Muslala

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Photo from Batsheva Dance Company, coming to the US in March.

The other piece is a post I made [on LinkedIn](#) last week about the need for arts presenters to include voices of Israeli artists, as they do Palestinian artists:

In case you aren't able to open the link:

[This is not the time to be afraid of backlash:](#)

[Last week's confluence of the Under the Radar Festival](#) and the [Association of Performing Arts Professionals](#) conference was a needed infusion of hope and optimism. I was proud and inspired to be among changemakers working through culture, a world I know and

believe in. I saw many productions - joyous, confounding, tragic and hilarious, by artists hailing from Russia, Africa, Europe and Palestine. Not one from Israel. I looked at programs. I asked AI. Nada. (Let me know if I missed something.)

Why am I bringing this up? I have worked with Israeli and Palestinian artists and cultural workers for years. I feel for both people regardless of their heinous leaders. Palestinians and Israelis are deeply attached to this land and both of them deserve to “live under their vine and fig tree and no one shall be afraid.”

This makes for an uncomfortable balancing act in the cultural arena. Many of my peers don’t know the long, complicated history of Israel/Palestine. Or the many nuances and complexities. Or don’t care to know. It is so easy to be on the bandwagon. And speaking out can be/is dangerous. So here I go:

Why were there no Israelis among the 100’s of performers here in NYC over the last two weeks?

My guess is that arts presenters and producers are scared. (kudos to BAM and others who are presenting the [Batsheva Dance Company](#) in March.) Too much exposure, too many possibilities of protests. Nasty emails, horrible social media. And on and on. Maybe they’re afraid of what happened at UC Berkeley: <https://lnkd.in/efkMSMjG>. Or they don’t want to push back against BDS. While I do not subscribe to it, BDS is popular - it has worked in some countries (to some extent) in changing government policies.

However, CULTURAL BOYCOTTS, purposeful or not, shut down any opportunity for the dialogue that must happen on both sides of the conflict for people to live there in safety and dignity. The Israeli artists I know are firmly on the side of justice for Palestinians. They need to be heard as much as Palestinian artists. The arts community must be willing to LISTEN to the perspectives of both groups and have compassion for both people.

As the ceasefire begins, I pray for the continuation of the deal that will grant a long-overdue reprieve to the surviving hostages and their families and to Gazan families who have been trapped in a devastating war for more than 15 months. There are Israelis and Palestinians working together to find ways to coexist peacefully like

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... Standing Together, Combatants for Peace,
Alliance for Middle East Peace - ALLMEP Artists have a special way of communicating ideas. We owe it to ourselves and our constituents to offer a platform to Palestinian AND Israeli artists who are able to express the nuances and personal experiences of this conflict. This is not the time to be afraid of backlash.



Vibha and I will be featured in the Rockefeller Foundation's Bellagio Center Newsletter this spring. We discuss her experience of and work in Jerusalem as well as the impact the Bellagio residency had on each of us. (I was a Fellow there in 2014 figuring out how to restructure the Jerusalem residency as an independent program. Vibha was an artist Fellow there in 2016.) Here's an excerpt from the article:

Art Opening Dialogue:

Vibha contends that in regard to global crises like climate change, division among people only hurts us more. "For me, climate change is the

I'll be in Jerusalem next week, meeting with leaders of past and

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potential host organizations in East and West Jerusalem who have all expressed interest in bringing back international artists. I will be there to learn how they envision the program in the coming years and how JIF can meet their needs as they move forward.

I'll report back in February.

Stay safe,

Elise

I'll cl



I want to support International Artists in Jerusalem

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